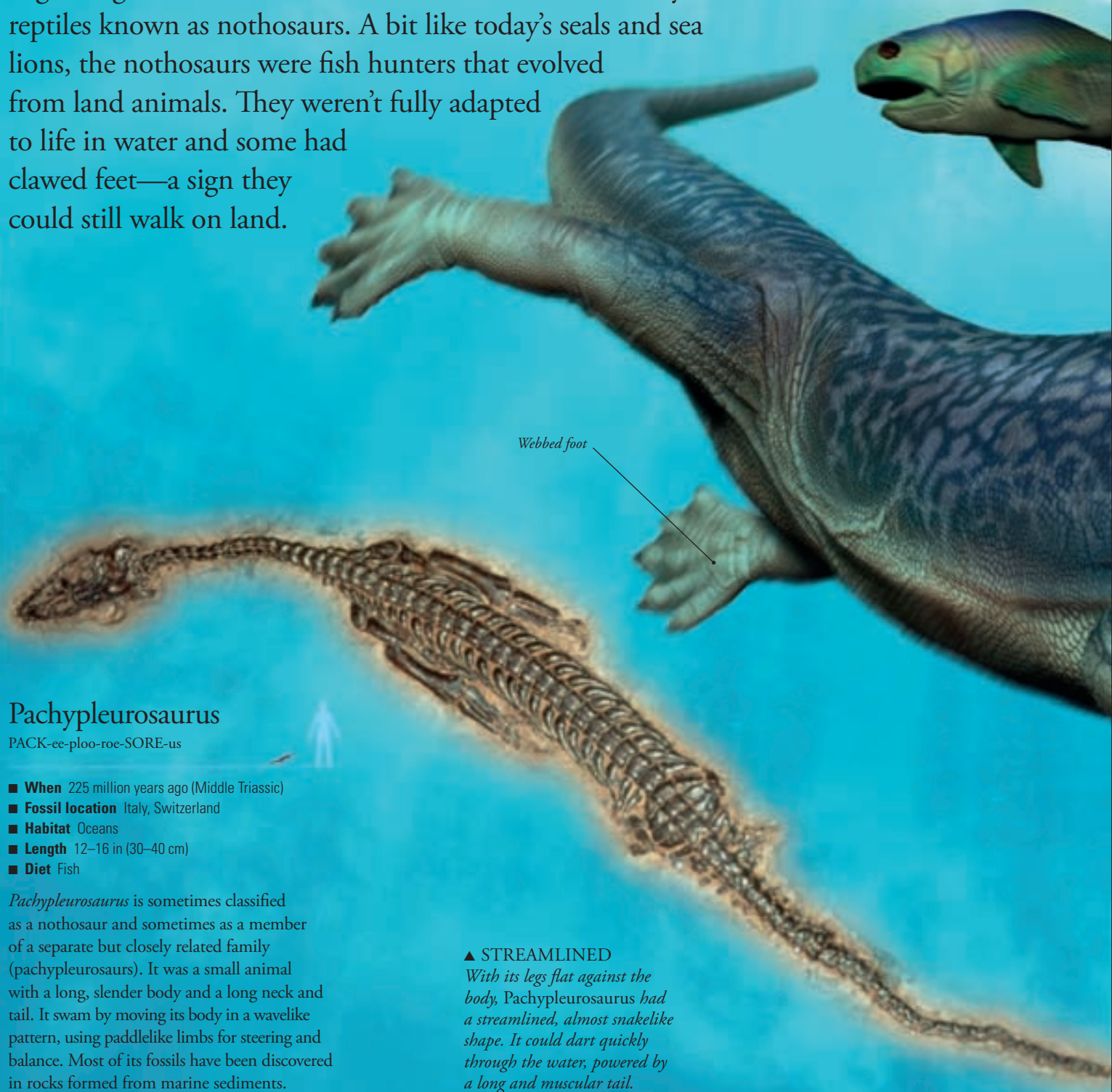


Nothosaurs

In the middle of the Triassic, when the first dinosaurs were beginning to walk on land, the seas were home to a family of reptiles known as nothosaurs. A bit like today's seals and sea lions, the nothosaurs were fish hunters that evolved from land animals. They weren't fully adapted to life in water and some had clawed feet—a sign they could still walk on land.



Pachypleurosaurus

PACK-ee-ploo-roe-SORE-us

- **When** 225 million years ago (Middle Triassic)
- **Fossil location** Italy, Switzerland
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 12–16 in (30–40 cm)
- **Diet** Fish

Pachypleurosaurus is sometimes classified as a nothosaur and sometimes as a member of a separate but closely related family (pachypleurosaurids). It was a small animal with a long, slender body and a long neck and tail. It swam by moving its body in a wavelike pattern, using paddlelike limbs for steering and balance. Most of its fossils have been discovered in rocks formed from marine sediments.

▲ STREAMLINED

With its legs flat against the body, Pachypleurosaurus had a streamlined, almost snakelike shape. It could dart quickly through the water, powered by a long and muscular tail.

